

Session 27: The Deaths of Rachel and Isaac

Key Takeaways

- Rakhel's difficult labor recalls both the promise of a victorious seed and the dire consequences for the woman in Genesis 3:15-16.
- Reuben's sexual assault against Bilhah is another instance in a pattern of illicit sex used in a grab for power.
- The four burials in Genesis 35 each recall moments of deception in Yaaqov's story.

Rakhel and Yitskhaq Die, Reuben's Treachery

¹⁶ And they journeyed on from Beth-El,
and it happened, while they were still a stretch of land from the entrance of Ephrathah,
that **Rakhel** gave birth ,
and **she had difficulty in giving birth** .

¹⁷ And it came about, while **she was having difficulty in giving birth** ,
that the midwife said to her,
 "Don't be afraid,
 because also this one is for you a **son**!"
¹⁸ And it came about, while her life was going out, because **she was dying**,
that **she called his name**,
 "**Son** of My Grief" (lit. "Ben-'oniy"),
but **his father called him**,
 "**Son of My Right Hand**" (lit. "**Ben-yamin**").

¹⁹ And **Rakhel died**,
 and she was buried on the road to Ephrathah
 (this is Beth-Lekhem).
²⁰ And Yaaqov **stood up a standing-stone** on **her burial**,
 (this is the standing stone of **the burial of Rakhel** unto today).

²¹ And Yisrael journeyed on,
and he set up his tent beyond "Tower of the Flock" [lit. "Migdal-Eder"].
²² And it came about when Yisrael was dwelling in that land,
that **Reuven** went and he laid with **Bilhah** , the concubine of his father,

and Yisrael heard of it.

And the sons of Yaaqov were twelve:

23 **Sons of** Leah:

The firstborn of Yaaqov was **Reuven**,
and Shim'on and Levi and Yehudah and Yissakar and Zebulun.

24 **Sons of** **Rakhel**:

Yoseph and **Benjamin**.

25 **Sons of** **Bilhah**, female slave of Rakhel:

Dan and Naphtali.

26 **Sons of** Zilpah, female slave of Leah:

Gad and Asher.

These are the sons of Yaaqov
who were born to him in Paddan-aram.

27 And Yaaqov went to **Yitskhaq** his father,
at Mamre, Qiryat-Arba' [= "City of the Four"],
(this is Hebron)
where Avraham and Yitskhaq had migrated.

28 And the days of Yitskhaq were one hundred and eighty years.

29 And **Yitskhaq** expired **and he died**,
and he was gathered to his fathers, old and full of days,
and **they buried him**, Esau and Yaaqov, his sons.

Genesis 35:16-29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The Many Burials

There are four "burial" notices in this collection of stories, three of people and one of idols, each illuminating the others.

Genesis 35:4: Idols	Genesis 35:6, 8: Deborah	Genesis 35:17-20: Rakhel	Genesis 35:29: Yitskhaq
And they gave to Yaaqov all the foreign gods (idols, ear rings), and he hid (טמן) them	And Yaaqov went to Luz ... (that is, Bethel) ... And she died (ותמת), Deborah the nursemaid	And as [Rakhel's] birth was harsh, her midwife said to her ... And she died (ותמת),	And Yitskhaq died (וימת) ... and they buried him (ויקברו),
Yaaqov Many Burials. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).			

Genesis 35:4: Idols	Genesis 35:6, 8: Deborah	Genesis 35:17-20: Rakhel	Genesis 35:29: Yitskhaq
under the oak (תחת האלה) which is in Shechem.	of Rebekah, and she was buried (ותקבר) under the oak (תחת האלון) and he called its name "Oak of Weeping."	Rakhel, and she was buried (ותקבר) on the road to Ephrathah (that is, Bethlehem), and Yaaqov set up a pillar upon her grave (that's the pillar of the grave of Rakhel unto today).	Esau and Yaaqov, his sons.
<i>Yaaqov Many Burials.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).			

Rakhel's death in [Genesis 35:19](#) is set on analogy to the death of Deborah, to the burial of the idols in [Genesis 35:4](#), and also to Yitskhaq's death which quickly follows.

The buried idols remind of us Rakhel's theft of those same idols in [chapter 31](#). Are we meant to conclude that her death is somehow connected to Yaaqov's words back in [Genesis 31:32](#)? "The one with whom your *elohim* are found, that one will not live!"

The death of Deborah reminds us of Rivqah's deception (in [ch. 27](#)) and the fact that her promise in [Genesis 27:45](#) to send for Yaaqov never came true. In fact, Rivqah is the only matriarch in Genesis whose death and burial goes unmentioned. Only her maidservant is named, and Deborah too dies as Yaaqov returns to the land.

"Genesis also tells us about the death and burial of each patriarch's favorite wife (Sarah, [Gen. 23:1-20](#); Rachel, [Gen. 35:19](#)). The exception is Rebekah, apart from the summarizing statement in [49:31](#). Presumably she died and was buried before Jacob returned from Aram-naharaim, for there is no reference to Jacob being reunited with Rebekah. Rebekah is gone, though survived by her nurse, but only until Jacob arrives. He not only does not get to see his mother, but he is forced to become undertaker for his late mother's nurse. Thus, one of Jacob's first experiences after coming back home is confronting death. By including the name Rebekah, the author helps his reader recall her character, she who instigated the deception of Isaac. Her punishment (implied at least) is that she will never get to see her son again."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1995). [The Book of Genesis, Chapters 18–50](#). Eerdmans. 378.

Yitskhaq's death brings the story full circle. Recall that at the beginning of [Genesis 27](#), Yitskhaq said that the day of his death may be near ([Gen. 27:1-3](#)). But in fact, he lived another 20 years, through Yaaqov's entire exile!

These four burials all link together because each one reminds the reader of some element of Yaaqov's deceptions in the past. As he returns to the land, he is surrounded by reminders of his past and of the deception and relational damage that he caused so many years ago.

- Burying the idols: Recalls Rakhel's deception of her father, which was parallel to Yaaqov's deception of his father Yitskhaq.

- Burying Deborah: Recalls Rivqah's deception of her husband, in league with Yaaqov, and how Yaaqov never saw his mother again.
- Burying Rakhel: Recalls Yaaqov's curse in Genesis 31:32, which said the one who stole the idols would die, while sadly, Yaaqov, the one who stole the blessing, lives on.
- Burying Yitskhaq: Recalls Yaaqov's deception of Yitskhaq, and how he died not long after he returned from the land.

Reuben's Lust for Power

The story of Reuben's rape of Bilhah is another sordid moment for the sons of Yaaqov. Within the larger frame of Genesis 33:18-35:29, there is a deliberate strategy to compare Reuben's behavior with Shechem, son of Hamor, from Genesis 34.

Yaaqov and Reuben	Yaaqov, Sh'khem, Shim'on, and Levi
Gen. 35:21 And Israel set out and he pitched his tent (ויט אהלה) from there to Migdal Eder	Gen. 33:18-20 Yaaqov went to the city of Shechem in the land of Canaan when he returned from Paddan-aram, and there he pitched his tent (נטה אהליו) ... and he set up (ויצב) an altar (מזבח)
Gen. 35:22 And while Israel dwelt in that land, Reuben went and laid with Bilhah, concubine of his father, and Israel heard of it .	Gen. 34 Shechem son of Khamor rapes Dinah daughter of Yaaqov Gen. 34:5 And Yaaqov heard that he had defiled Dinah his daughter ... and Yaaqov kept silent . Simeon and Levi deceive and murder the men of Shechem.
Gen. 49:3-4 Reuben , you are my firstborn; my might and the beginning of my strength, preeminent in dignity and preeminent in power. Uncontrolled as water, you shall not have preeminence, because you went up to your father's bed; then you defiled it—he went up to my couch .	Gen. 49:5-7 Simeon and Levi are brothers; their swords are implements of violence . Let my soul not enter into their council; let not my glory be united with their assembly; because in their anger they murdered men , and in their self-will they lamed oxen. Cursed be their anger, for it is fierce; and their wrath, for it is cruel. I will disperse them in Yaaqov, and scatter them in Israel.
Yaaqov, Reuben, and Sh'khem Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

In both sequences, Yaaqov pitches a tent right before a disaster hits his family.

In the first sequence, Shechem rapes Yaaqov's daughter, leading to the violent revenge carried out by his second- and third-born sons. In the second sequence, Reuben rapes Yaaqov's concubine, who was the slave of Rakhel who just died.

Through this parallelism, Reuben is compared to both the abusive Shechem and to his violent brothers. Notice that in Genesis 49, all three come in for critique and curse.

While Reuben's motives are not stated, the reader is invited into a whole network of narrative patterns where illicit sex is a way of challenging one's rival.

- The sons of *Elohim* (Gen. 6:1-4)
- Ham "seeing the nakedness of his father" (Gen. 9:18-23)
- Lot's daughters having drunk sex with their father in the cave (Gen. 19:30-38)
- Leah attempting to buy the conjugal rights of Yaaqov (Gen. 30:14-16)
- Abner sleeping with Saul's concubine (2 Sam. 3:7-8)
- Absalom raping David's concubines (2 Sam. 15:16 and 16:22)
- Adoniyah's request to sleep with David's concubine (1 Kings 2:13-25)

"This incident is directly linked to the foregoing because it is Rachel's demise that presents the occasion for Reuben's act. By violating Bilhah, Reuben makes sure that she cannot supplant or even rival his mother's [Leah's] position of chief wife now that Rachel is dead ... In this connection, it is interesting that Reuben had earlier been involved in the attempt to get his father to restore the conjugal rights of his mother (30:14-16). As a result of Reuben's cohabitation with Bilhah, she would thereby acquire the tragic status of 'living widowhood ...' All this leads to the conclusion that Reuben's bid to promote his mother's rights is at the same time a calculated challenge to his father's authority. His move is more political than lustful. The summary account in this verse hides an attempt to usurp the leadership of the Israelite tribes. Its failure is reflected in Jacob's rebuke of 49:3-4, in which he removes Reuben from hegemony over the tribes."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*Genesis, The JPS Torah Commentary*](#). JPS. 245.

Reflection Question

How do the curses and consequences of Genesis 3:14-19 continue to show up in the Yaaqov story?